Trade deals impose regulations on who can use what. These work against small-scale farmers but favor the powerful agricultural corporations that produce the seed.



Californian rice production is high yield but there are problems with soil salinity. Although salt tolerance can be genetically introduced, traditional rice varieties can be naturally salt-resistant.

“Seed patents threaten the very survival and freedom of peasants … and farmers …”

Vandana Shiva

Seed sovereignty

Shiva argues that rural farms are threatened if the appropriate seed is no longer available. Traditionally, most small-scale farmers routinely save their seed from one harvest to the next. Now, when farmers buy in seed—especially if it is genetically modified—they often have to agree not to save it. Having to buy seed from a company every year can leave them worse off financially.

Shiva criticized the practice of corporations patenting seed varieties as “biopiracy” and set up Navdanya to support “seed sovereignty.” It